Beaver Valley: a game idea, and I want your honest feedback

Page 1. The pitch

Beaver Valley is a working title. The real name is not chosen. The game does not exist in finished form yet: what you have been given is an idea and some decisions, and the art is placeholder.

What it is

A cozy farming game that you play in a web browser or on a tablet. You inherit a run-down farm, grow crops, forage in the wild, sell what you make, and slowly rebuild the village hall with the village's help. It is in the spirit of Stardew Valley and similar games, but with its own world, characters and story.

Who it is for

People who like relaxed games with no pressure. There are no timers that end the game, no game over, and a bad day costs you very little. It is a free hobby project made by one person, so it will stay small at first and grow in layers.

The feel we are aiming for

- **Cozy and unhurried.** A good evening is a few small decisions, some progress, a little curiosity, and a smile.
- **Funny and warm.** Affectionate jokes about everyday life and eccentric neighbours. Never grim.
- **A world with a past.** Old roads, ruins and a quiet shadow in the distance, but the shadow is backdrop, not a threat to you.
- **Your own pace.** Nothing tells you what to do. A neighbour nudges you toward the village hall. That is all.

What matters most, in this order

1. **Farming and crafting.** The core of every day.
2. **Expeditions.** Day trips to wilder places, bringing goods home to the farm.
3. **Relationships.** Villagers you get to know, who matter from your first week and grow closer over time.

How to read this packet

Pages 2 and 3 describe the setting and how the game plays. Pages 4 to 6 are the feedback sheets. Please read pages 1 to 3 once, on your own, then fill in the sheets before we talk. There are no right answers. "This bored me" and "I did not get this" are the most useful things you can write.

Page 2. The setting

The premise

You inherit a neglected farm from a relative who has vanished down the road. They were a quiet, shrewd gardener who loved rare seeds and went off adventuring to find more. They left a trunk of odd seeds and one plain note: *"The soil is good, the neighbours are better, do come and meet them."* Your family name is Thimblemoss.

The valley and its people

The valley is warm and quiet. Its people are the **Brimmers**: small, with long ears that poke out around elaborate hats. They have a hat for every occasion and trade. They keep **favour ledgers**, where neighbours write down favours given and owed, and they are hospitable to a fault. They do these things out of habit and no longer remember why.

One idea we like and want to test: a Brimmer's hat shows their standing in the ledger. A newcomer wears a plain cap, a respected host wears something grand, and your own hat grows as you do favours.

The past

Long ago a kingdom stood along the old road. A dark lord broke it and was in turn driven back and banished far away. The valley was the kingdom's kitchen garden, and it survived because it was too small and dull to be worth his trouble. Its folk are descended from the kingdom's servants.

The dark lord is not in the game as a character you meet. He is a **Hollow Crown**, an empty crown and robes that rule without a body, with shadow and a great voice mixed in. (The name and idea are a draft.) His influence can leak back in as strange creatures at the far edges of the map, but never in the home valley.

The town and the hall

Down the road is **Hearthwell**, a crossroads town where all kinds of travellers pass through: tall road-folk, stout craftspeople, fey wanderers. Its heart is **The Long Table**, the village hall, once an old waystation (an inn and a granary) where travellers rested, ate and were seen on their way. Restoring it is the first big goal. The town also has a general store, a smithy, an inn and kitchen, a healer, a library and a festival green.

A group called the **Dawn Carriers** work as couriers, carrying post and parcels between towns. Cheerful on the surface, they are secretly wardens who still watch the road. Later, one breaks cover to tell you the road is not as safe as it was.

Other peoples and festivals

Besides Brimmers, there is a forgetful wizard-like hermit in the woods who knew your relative and is the nearest thing to an answer about where they went, dwarves in the mountains, and elves. The first festival of the year is a **hat parade**, where everyone shows off their best hat and their standing in the ledger.

The ending

There is no real ending. When the last bundle for the village hall is finished there is a village feast and a short scene, and then you keep playing.

Page 3. How it plays

A day

Each day runs from morning to the small hours. You have limited energy, so a day is a set of choices: water the crops, forage, sell, visit someone, or go to bed early. Running out of energy means you pass out and wake at home, with a small cost. Nothing gets worse just because time passes. Seasons turn, and that is all.

Farming and foraging

You plant, water and harvest crops. Each crop has a season, a growth time and a price. Wild goods grow near the farm and change with the season. Doing things levels up your farming and foraging skills, which improves the quality of your goods and lets you choose a specialty at level 5 (for example, crops that sell for more, or crops that grow faster). You can upgrade your tools in the shop. Weather matters: rain waters your plots, and you can check tomorrow’s forecast before you sleep.

The village hall bundles

This is the main goal. The village hall asks for sets of goods: for example, “any 4 of these 6 spring wild plants” or “three kinds of summer crop”. You hand items in one at a time, the hall remembers its progress, and finishing a bundle gives a reward such as seeds or money. The first version has five bundles. Some goods only exist in one season, so over time both farming and foraging matter.

The world widens

The world is a set of rings around your home valley.

- **Ring 1, the home valley.** Farm, village and hall. Open from the start, safe and cozy.
- **Ring 2, the regions.** Four or five different places (think woods, marsh, mountain), each with its own goods and people. This opens partway through the hall chain, when one bundle mends the old bridge. Each region then needs its own tool or bridge to reach. This is where the shadow first shows up.
- **Ring 3, the dark edge.** Optional and late, behind a second, larger community project. Not designed yet.

Expeditions are day trips with limited energy and pack space. What you bring back feeds your farm and the next community project.

People

Every villager has a friendship value. You talk to them daily, give gifts (they love some, like some, and dislike some), watch a heart meter fill, and see small events. Friendship earns recipes, discounts and requests. This matters from your first week. Over many updates we hope to reach a cast about as big as Stardew Valley’s, but that will be built up in layers.

What is built so far

A playable first version exists in the browser with placeholder art: the day cycle, farming, foraging, skills, a shop, the hall with five bundles, saving, and a title and end screen. Villagers, the wider world and the story are still only designs.

Page 4. Feedback sheet 1: you and your first impression

Thank you. Write whatever comes to mind. Short answers are fine. Scribble in the margins of pages 1 to 3 wherever something confused you, delighted you, or made you roll your eyes.

Your name (or initials): _____ Date: _____

About you

Which of these games have you played, and roughly how many hours? (Stardew Valley, Animal Crossing, Harvest Moon, Story of Seasons, Rune Factory, Fae Farm, Coral Island, Dave the Diver, other cozy games.)

How would you describe yourself? Circle one. **Cozy-game fan / Plays occasionally / Rarely plays games / Other: _____**

What do you usually like most in this kind of game? (farming, collecting, decorating, characters, story, exploring, the routine, other)

Gut reaction

In your own words, in one or two sentences: what is this game?

Would you play it? Circle one. **Definitely / Probably / Maybe / Probably not / No**

What is the one thing that made you most want to play?

What is the one thing that made you least want to play, or that you did not believe?

Quick ratings

Circle a number from 1 (not for me) to 5 (love it).

The overall idea	1	2	3	4	5
The setting and its tone	1	2	3	4	5
The way a day works	1	2	3	4	5
The village hall as the main goal	1	2	3	4	5
The world widening in rings	1	2	3	4	5
The villagers and friendship	1	2	3	4	5
The names	1	2	3	4	5

Page 5. Feedback sheet 2: setting and story

The Brimmers and their hats

Do small, long-eared, hat-wearing, ledger-keeping, very hospitable people sound like a place you would want to spend time? Circle one. **Yes / Mostly / Unsure / Not really**

What would you change or add about them?

The hat shows your standing in the ledger, and your own hat grows as you do favours. Does this sound fun, silly, or pointless?

The past and the shadow

The dark lord is not a character you meet, only a distant influence. Does that feel right for a cozy game, too weak, or about right?

Does the story make you curious about what happened to your relative, the kingdom, and the road? What would you want to find out?

The hall and the Dawn Carriers

Does the village hall being the old waystation (an inn and granary) make restoring it feel more meaningful? Why or why not?

Couriers who are secretly wardens: fun, cliché, or confusing? _____

The ending

There is no real ending, only a feast and a short scene when the last hall bundle is done, and then you play on. Circle one. **Satisfying / Fine / Disappointing / I would want a real ending**

What would you want to happen at that point?

Tone

Is it too silly, too serious, or about right? _____

The names

For each name, circle: **Like it / Fine / Dislike it**. Write any alternative that comes to mind.

Name	Your verdict	Alternative
Beaver Valley (working title)	Like / Fine / Dislike	
Brimmers	Like / Fine / Dislike	
Thimblemoss	Like / Fine / Dislike	
Hearthwell	Like / Fine / Dislike	
The Long Table	Like / Fine / Dislike	
Dawn Carriers	Like / Fine / Dislike	
Hollow Crown	Like / Fine / Dislike	

Does anything remind you too much of another book, film or game? _____

Page 6. Feedback sheet 3: how it plays, and anything else

The day

A day has limited energy, and you choose what to spend it on. Passing out costs a little money and some energy the next morning. Is that the right amount of pressure, too much, or too little?

Farming and foraging

What would make farming interesting for you for many hours? What would make it a chore?

Specialties at level 5 (for example, crops sell for more, or crops grow faster) and tool upgrades from the shop: are these good reasons to keep playing?

The village hall bundles

You hand in sets of goods, some “any 4 of these 6”. Would you enjoy that, and what would make it feel better (for example, hints, a list in the notebook, a reward you can look forward to)?

The rings and expeditions

The valley is safe, and the wider world opens partway through the hall chain, region by region, as you get new tools and mend the bridge. Does that sound like a good way to unlock a world, or would you rather it all be open from the start?

Expeditions are day trips with limited energy and pack space, bringing goods home. What do you want to find out there?

Villagers

Friendship starts in the first week: daily talk, gifts, hearts and small events. Which would you most want from this? (stories, romance, gifts, helping them, shared work, secrets, funny scenes, other)

How many villagers would you want to know well, and how many is too many?

The big questions

What is missing? What did you expect to see that was not there?

What would make you stop playing after the first few hours?

What would make you play for 40 hours or more?

Anything else, including things you scribbled in the margins that you want to explain?

Thank you. Please hand this back by: _____